

CORE FORMULA

Notice energy -> close respectfully -> bridge to a live thread -> offer choice -> calibrate after the switch. -> Compact: "This topic may be complete for now. The more useful thread seems to be X. Want to move there?" -> Soft: "I might be wrong, but the energy seems to be more around X than Y. Should we follow X for a bit?" -> Meeting: "We seem to have enough on this point. Unless there is a live concern, I suggest we move to the next decision."

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

That may be enough on this for now. Want to switch gears?

BEST FOR

- Casual conversations that have gone flat
- Meetings that start circling the same points
- Interviews where one thread clearly becomes more productive
- Networking conversations that need a warmer lane
- Digital threads that have reached closure
- Facilitation where the room's energy points to a better working topic

PHRASE BANK

Quick pivots · Short starter lines

- "That may be enough on this for now. Want to switch gears?"
- "I think this one's done its job. Shall we move on?"
- "Want to switch to something lighter for a bit?"
- "Should we park this and pick up the next part?"
- "That feels mostly answered. Move on?"
- "Good spot to leave it - shall we follow the livelier thread?"
- "Enough on this, or is there more you want to say?"

Social / gentle pivot · Warm, low-pressure

- "This bit may have run its course. Want to switch to something lighter for a minute?"
- "That connects to something I was curious about - how did you get into it in the first place?"
- "We've covered the formal version. I'm curious what part of the work you actually enjoy most."
- "You lit up a second ago - can we follow that instead?"
- "That's a good place to leave it. What have you been enjoying lately?"
- "I could stay on this, but I'd love the fun part - what happened after that?"

Professional / meetings · Decisions and status

- "We seem to have enough on that point. I suggest we move to the next decision unless there is a live concern."
- "We may be circling. Shall we move to the decision unless someone has new information?"
- "This point feels settled. Any objection to moving to the next item?"
- "Unless there's a live concern, I'd like to move us to what we decide next."
- "We've got enough to decide. Shall I move us on?"
- "That's well covered. The next open question is timing - can we go there?"

Name the energy and steer · One-to-one, explicit read

- "The energy seems less around the prices and more around adoption. Should we move there?"
- "You sounded more interested when you mentioned the design side. Should we follow that for a bit?"

- "I notice we both got more specific when the practical part came up. Want to follow that instead of staying abstract?"
- "I don't want to drag this if it's no longer useful. The live issue seems to be timeline, not background - can we move there?"
- "The room is giving more energy to option C. I'm going to test whether C is the working thread."
- "The useful thread seems to be what happens next. Shall we go there?"

Recovery after a fast switch · Undo without defensiveness

- "I may have moved on too quickly. Do you want to stay with the previous point?"
- "Let me rewind - that topic may still matter."
- "I treated that as complete, but I might have misread it."
- "We can absolutely stay there. I don't want to force the pace."
- "I changed lanes for efficiency, but the old lane may still be the real one."
- "That switch was mine, not the conversation's - where would you rather be?"

Consent before switching · Emotional care, high stakes

- "Before I change topics, is this something you want heard more fully?"
- "I don't want to move on just because this is quiet. Is this something you want to stay with?"
- "This feels important even though it's gone quiet. Shall we stay here?"
- "We can switch topics; we don't need to solve this right now."
- "Before I redirect, is there anything else that needs to be heard on this?"
- "I'd rather not rush past this. Do you want more time on it?"

Digital / async · Chat and email threads

- "This thread feels mostly answered. I can park it and switch to the implementation question."
- "I think this thread's answered - I'll park it unless you want more. Next useful question is timing."
- "Happy to close this one out. Want me to open a fresh thread on delivery?"
- "Parking this for now - shall we pick up the next question?"
- "This one's wrapped, I think. Moving to timing unless you've got more."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "Anyway, moving on."

Better: "That may be enough on this topic. Want to switch gears?"

Best: "I think this topic has probably done its job for now. The useful thread seems to be what happens next - shall we move there?"

2. Weak: "This is boring."

Better: "I'm not sure this thread has much energy left."

Best: "I notice we both got more specific when the practical part came up. Want to follow that instead of staying abstract?"

3. Weak: "Let's talk about something else."

Better: "Can I change the subject?"

Best: "I don't want to cut this off if it matters. If it feels complete, I'd like to switch to the decision point."

4. Weak: "You're stuck on this."

Better: "Maybe we can come back to this."

Best: "We may be circling. I can either ask one clarifying question, or we can park it and move to the part you seem more interested in."

DECISION TREE

If The topic is still producing useful detail, emotion, decision movement, or connection.

Stay with it or deepen - do not switch.

"Say more about that."

If Energy is low, but the topic is difficult, vulnerable, risky, or about accountability.

Check importance before switching; do not move away from it.

"I don't want to move on just because this is quiet. Do you want to stay with it?"

If Energy is low and the topic is simply complete or stale.

Close it respectfully and look for a more alive adjacent thread.

"That may be enough on this for now. Want to switch gears?"

If There is a more alive adjacent thread.

Bridge to it rather than jumping to a random topic.

"That connects to something I was curious about..."

If There is no obvious next thread.

Offer a choice or ask a preference question instead of inventing one.

"Where would you rather take this?"

If You switched, but the energy did not improve.

Repair, ask a preference question, or return to the old topic.

"I may have moved on too quickly. Want to go back?"

SCENARIOS

Casual conversation loses detail - answers shorten, eye contact drops, and both people repeat known facts.

Close the topic lightly and offer a new adjacent track; follow them back if they return. — "This may have done its job. Want to switch to the fun part - what happened after that?"

A meeting starts circling - people restate positions without adding new evidence.

Name enoughness and move to the decision or next evidence, keeping an objection path open. — "We may be circling. I suggest we move to the decision unless someone has new information."

A person lights up on a side point - their voice quickens and examples become specific.

Test a switch toward the livelier thread. — "You sounded more interested when you mentioned the design side. Should we follow that for a bit?"

A digital thread becomes stale - replies are delayed, repetitive, or reduced to acknowledgements.

Mark closure and offer the new useful topic; answer the old thread if they ask for more. — "I think this thread is answered. I'll park it unless you want more; the next useful question is timing."

A sensitive topic looks low-energy but important - the person is quiet, but the stakes are high.

Do not switch without permission; check importance first. — "I don't want to move on just because this is quiet. Is this something you want to stay with?"

A networking chat needs a graceful pivot - the shared professional topic has gone generic.

Bridge to a more personal-but-safe topic and follow any values-based answer. — "We've covered the formal version. I'm curious what part of the work you actually enjoy most."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The person is in active emotion
- Safety, consent, legal, medical, or accountability issues are unresolved
- The topic is quiet because it is hard but important
- The person has explicitly asked to stay on the topic
- Switching would protect your comfort at their expense
- A power difference could make the switch feel like control
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Energy cue spotting

Across three conversations today, note one cue that energy was rising, one that it was falling, and one cue you could easily misread.

Day 2 — Read the ambiguity

Take five "low-energy" moments and, for each, write the two most likely reasons (complete, bored, tired, private, or difficult-but-important). Practise not assuming the first one.

Day 3 — Respectful close

Write five ways to mark a topic as "enough for now" without ever implying it was boring, wrong, or a waste of time.

Day 4 — Bridge construction

Take five flat topics and write one adjacent bridge for each. Avoid abrupt, unrelated jumps.

Day 5 — Offer the choice

Rewrite five of your closes so the switch is a suggestion the other person can decline, not a command.

Day 6 — Recovery reps

Say three repair lines aloud until they sound natural: "I may have moved on too quickly," "We can absolutely stay there," and "I might have misread that."

Day 7 — Meeting version

In one real conversation or meeting, convert a circling discussion into a decision move without blaming the group, then check whether energy improved.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I switch because the conversation needed it, or because I wanted relief?
- Did I check for emotion, stakes, or unresolved accountability first?
- Did I close the old topic respectfully, without implying it was boring?
- Was the new topic adjacent and useful, or clearly offered as a choice?
- Did the other person show more detail, energy, or ease after the switch?
- If I misread it, did I repair without defensiveness and preserve their dignity?